Last Hurrah

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39756027.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

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by Jezmatron

Summary

Adora SUCKS at dating. She just can't seem to land a date.

Even when they are throwing themselves at her. She just doesn't get it.

So, when she gets a chance to take part in a dating game show, with the chance to definitely, 100% go on a date with an actual other woman, she leaps at the chance. Or rather she gets shoved at the chance by her cousin and brother.

But maybe the contestants aren't who has her interest piqued. Will she overcome her obliviousness? Will the contest go off without a hitch?

...of course not. Let's hope someone else takes the initiative.

Notes

For those of you who might be confused, this is based on the premise of Blind Date - a tv show that aired in the UK on ITV in the late 90's and early 2000's.

The premise is simple - a man/woman asks questions to 3 unknown suitors and they deliver tawdry puns and innuendo laden replies back. (The earlier series had more open ended responses). There's a whole other segment where the prior week's contestants get interviewed BUT I have omitted that for brevity's sake.

Anyway, I hope you enjoy me transplanting poor Adora and Catra into the weird world of cheesy gameshows.

Thank you to Petty_Labelle and Vertical_Drive for beta-ing most of this before I binged the last third of it this evening! Your feedback and edits were MUCH NEEDED!

See the end of the work for more notes

"*See!* I told you having it *up* would be simply *ah-may-zing* ."

Adora stared into the mirror and managed a smile. That is to say, the corners of her mouth creaked up and her eyebrows rose. She managed to get out a faint, "It looks…. Good?"

The stylist leaned around her and smiled. They had introduced themselves as *"Trouble, but Double it!"* then laughed before setting to on this rather extravagant makeover.

Honestly, Adora didn't *hate* the look. But it most definitely was a far cry from her normal attire. She was used to flannel shirts, sports bras, and grey leggings. Relaxed wear. Go-to-the-gym-then-veg-on-the-couch wear. Not *this* . They'd got her dolled up in a strappy red dress. " *Better to show off the assets, darling* ," the stylist had claimed. And, honestly, it *did* show them off: her shoulders looked amazing, her arms defined, and her legs looked somehow even longer. While she saw herself as gangly, even Adora had to admit it looked pretty good. You could now *see* the effort she'd been putting in at the gym.

So, yeah, she didn't hate it. And, maybe, just maybe, this was a reason why she'd had a difficult time securing the attention of (to not put too fine a point on it) the ladies.

Which, of course, was why she was in this chair getting a makeover in the first place.

“Blondie all ready?” came a voice from the door. It startled Adora and did strange things to her. Her stomach fluttered and she blinked rapidly. In the mirror, she caught a glimpse of frizzy brown hair and a face covered in freckles. The woman looked distracted, speaking idly into a headset mic as she regarded a tablet clutched in one hand. Trouble spun Adora in her chair, whirled and practically skipped across the small dressing room to the woman.

“Honey, she is a *vision* . Going to set your ratings on *fih-YAH* ”

The woman looked up and gave the stylist a flat look before she spoke, her voice a sardonic drawl, “I told you to tone it down. Not buying that schtick.”

“Ugh, still no fun, Kitten. Anyhoo, she’s good to go. A bit of a salvage job, but once I cut away the U-Haul lesbian exterior, burned it with fire, and allowed myself to let loose, well… voila!”

The brunette turned her gaze to Adora, a faint smirk on her face. Her eyes settled on the blonde and she blinked. Then she blinked again.

For her part, Adora’s breath hitched in her chest. The woman in front of her was *stunning* . Definitely freckled, light caramel skin, frizzy brunette hair, and heterochromatic eyes that were so bright they just drew you in. She had the hint of an elongated canine, visible in her smirk. The woman appeared to be frozen as well. Though Adora couldn’t fathom why. Maybe she was just super stressed..

Trouble glanced from the woman to Adora, then back again. They arched an eyebrow, then suddenly gave a start as a smile spread across their face, "NO!"

The woman shook herself and turned a glare on the stylist, "Don't…"

"I cannot…"

"Don't say it…" Double mimed a zip across their mouth, then winked, before they spun back towards Adora. The woman coughed and averted her gaze, "Up in the studio in five, ok, Blondie."

"Adora," she felt she needed to say *something* . And being referred to as *blondie* irked Adora, "My name is Adora."

The brunette paused and turned back, cocking her head to one side. Her expression softened for a moment. "Well. Of course it is. Alright, *Adora* . On set in five."

And with that the woman was gone. Double hummed as they made the final touches to Adora's poofed up and styled hair, before they leaned in with a grin and said, "Wow. She likes you. Not even a single swear word. Never thought I'd see the day. Shame she's not a contestant, huh?"

Adora blinked in surprise, then frowned at the stylist, “Wait, what?”

“What? I mean, you’re gonna knock ‘em dead out there, babe. Now, let’s get you upstairs!”

As Adora was hustled out of the dressing room, she pondered whether this whole venture was a good idea.

It had started a few months prior. Adam and Mara had been teasing her about her perpetual misfortune with dating. It had been in good fun, but Adora had been striking out *badly* for the past few months. Or, rather, she hadn’t really been *trying* . Her focus had been work and the gym. Before that, girls had gone beet red and fled at any attempt by Adora to engage or ask them on dates. And Adora got tongue tied when she tried, so she came across as this lumbering, gurning *mess* .

She was a useless lesbian. She knew this. It was fact. She was more comfortable in the gym, but also knew how gross it was to try to pick people up *at* the gym. The last thing any person wanted was someone letching them on the treadmill, or creeping near a squat rack. She’d watched, even as girls seemed to gravitate to machines around her. But she was well behaved and respected their privacy. She gave up machines, smiled and withdrew, knowing they wouldn’t want her cramping their style. She averted her eyes in the locker room too. Even helped find extra towels, because for some reason the girls always seemed to be lacking them (she’d raised *that* issue with the gym’s management). Clearly, they needed to provide *more* towels as the poor women were clearly running short or the men were hogging them!

Oddly, no one had thanked her for that yet.

Either way, Adora knew she needed to take drastic action.

It was a routine for their family (her twin, Adam, and their cousin, Mara) to crater on a Saturday to watch some god-awful quiz shows and dating contests. They all shared an apartment in Thaymor, so it was a cheap night in. Especially now that they were into their post-college, new career phase. It was during one of these regular get togethers, with Adam texting his maybe-sort-of-totally-in-love-with girl, Teela, that Mara had leaned forward from her chair, mismatched glass of wine in hand, and gestured at the TV.

They were watching *"Mystacor Mix",* a particularly cringe-worthy dating show: a lucky suitor had three questions to pitch to three mystery options. Their answers veered between bawdy to downright filth, or fell flatter than…. something very flat. That evening, a pale man with bloodshot eyes and slicked back blue hair was trying to answer the suitor's question. She was a tiny thing with purple hair all over the place, but she seemed enthralled with his rambling answer.

"You should try that," Mara had said. Adora had stared at her blankly and the woman had rolled her eyes, "Go on the show! I mean, you have a captive audience who KNOW what you're there for. And you know what they're there for. No chance for, y'know," Mara had taken a sip of her drink, "missed signals."

Adam had glanced up from his phone and nudged Adora with his foot. He was sprawled on their couch, while she sat on the floor, "Yep. Mara has a point. I swear, Adora, you're so bad at clocking when a girl likes you."

"I…. am not!"

The other two had just stared at her, while on the TV an argument had broken out between the other two contestants as the blue-haired dude stood nervously beside the painted plywood divider that was pulled away. Clearly he'd wooed the crazy bundle of energy, who promptly jumped him as soon as the obstacle was removed.

Mara sighed, "Adora, you … look, it would take longer than we have on this planet to point things out to you so… just give it a go. It could be fun."

"I am not signing up for a game show to embarrass myself on TV!" Adora had harrumphed.

"Too late. Just signed you up," Adam had held his phone up, "And for the record, Teela thinks it's a great idea. She can't watch you die in the clubs any more. She can only take so much obliviousness. I mean, you even returned that number a girl gave you that last time!"

"It… it was on a receipt. I thought she'd dropped it. And, y'know, it's important to keep accurate records of your finances!" Adora had sputtered.

The other two had just laughed, but the seed had been planted. Much as she objected, Adora had felt at sea a bit, around the whole dating debacle. And even if things were *that* drastic on the romance front (she definitely didn't feel they were *that* bad - after all, when she *had* tried to talk to girls, it was *them* who excused themselves).

And, after a week, the letter had arrived inviting her on the show for an audition. She'd arrived at the studio after a post-work gym session and the audition seemed to just go by so fast. She'd walked in and watched as the show host, a black-haired woman known as Casta, just did a double take and yelled out a *"YES! HER!"*

And with that, she had been slated to take part in the show.

Mara had taken her out for a pre-show drink, where they'd met up with Hope, Mara's girlfriend. Adam and Teela had joined them later, where they all toasted Adora's impending success with a roared *"FINALLY!"*

She'd taken it on the chin, and gotten her own jabs in about her relative's sickening domesticity. In reality she had other reasons to be worried about her perpetual singledom. Mara and Adam were very likely to take those dreaded "next steps" with their other halves: moving in together. Which would leave Adora alone. Which she was fine with. Totally fine with. One. Hundred. Per. Cent.

But it did feel like she was being left behind. And she *knew* , really, that she wasn't great at meeting people, making friends, reading situations, and so on. So having to get out there, solo, was daunting. She could live alone if she knew that, out there, at the end of a phone, there was someone she wouldn't be bothering with a call - she wouldn't be interrupting a date night or something. Because that person would be *hers* .

So, yes. This was a real hail mary.

Adora shook herself as Trouble escorted her through the studio's back corridors, until they reached the set itself.

Up close, it really was smoke and mirrors - not that it was particularly glitzy on TV, but in the here and now, it was all cheap plastic, plywood, and bright lights. The backdrop for the whole set was a pastel wall, inlaid with a rainbow zig zag and bulbous lights that flashed in rhythm. What stood out from the simple set was the slightly raised part of the stage, which was lit from below by blinking LEDS and floor-lamps. A single stool stood upon it - that was for her.

That infamous plywood partition separated her position from the other three stools where her suitors would sit. They had a curtained entrance on the other side of the studio, which would be out of Adora's eye line once she was sat down.

As she gazed around the studio her eyes caught on the familiar brunette. The woman turned and froze as Adora wobbled her way into the set in the ridiculous heels Trouble had insisted she wear.

They made her already tall form look positively gigantic and also made her feel like a newborn giraffe. She was sure she looked like an idiot - the fact that half the crew were staring, slack jawed, just confirmed it.

Adora managed a little wave to the brunette, who waved back, although she seemed distracted, maybe a little dazed when she did so. Adora imagined the poor woman was fairly stressed - it seemed a hectic job.

She made it to the stool without tripping, flailing, or otherwise accidentally concussing either herself or any nearby crew-members. Trouble got her situated, then fussed about her, smoothing down the dress and double checking the hair, "You look fabulous, darling. You're gonna break hearts. Well, at least *one* so far at any rate."

And with that, they were gone. Adora blinked owlishly. All of a sudden she felt unsure; incredibly alone all of a sudden as sje sat there and fidgeted as the crew bustled about, getting cameras sorted and checking lights. She startled slightly as a young woman with blue highlights in her hair stepped alongside her and held up some sort of device with a number reading on it.

The woman was short and seemed annoyed, "Okay, adjust number 3 and 4 on the lighting rig. Jeez, you're tall." That last bit seemed to be addressed to Adora, albeit in a sideways manner. The girl gave Adora a quick once over, then shrugged and turned back to the cameras, "And we need a shorter stool. Even Casta's gonna have to look up with this one! Uh… that okay, Catra?"

The brunette, who Adora noted was now talking to a few of the camera people, half turned and waved a hand, "Yeah, alright, Frosta. Get it done. OK, all good on the lighting check. Someone get Adora. Off set, in the wings, ready for the entrance. We're good to go in ten, people, for initial take."

Adora watched the whirlwind, then flinched a bit as a young man with messy blond hair gently tapped her on the shoulder, "Uh, um, hey? So, uh, we need you off the set, so they can run the contestant intro? The *other* contestants, I mean." He smiled apologetically and Adora nodded quickly, before she stood and let herself be led off-st into a curtained off part of the stage. The young man leaned out from the curtains and spoke to someone else, his voice muffled. A moment later he turned back to Adora and held up a small clip-on mic and transmitter, "Just, y'know, gotta get this on. Did DT tell you where they put the pouch?"

"Pouch?" Adora frowned, puzzled.

"Yeah, for the transmitter. Ruins the shot, y'know, if you've got a bulge," he blinked, "Um, I mean, y'know cos, um."

Adora flushed and coughed. Another face poked around the curtain, a black girl with cornrows. She huffed, "Kyle, you messing around?"

"Uh, no I, uh… just…"

The woman stepped into the isolation area and plucked the mic from the young man's hands, "Sorry about this, get's all weird. So, uh… yep, looks like DT put the pouch on the back, so let's just… yep…" And a moment later, Adora had a surreptitious transmitter fastened inside her dress, along with a with a handily disguised mic clipped to the front, "Alright, done. And woah, you are gonna knock 'em dead. If my boy and his boy here hadn't got me on lockdown, I'd be shovin' one of those girls off a stool."

And with that, and a cocky smirk, the woman was gone, the young man dragged away behind her. Adora drew a deep breath and eyed the lights above. She could hear a voice, all school-marm charm and fluting enthusiasm as it drifted over the set and she realised they were doing an intro. Beyond that she could also hear the shuffling of feet and she swallowed - the studio *audience* .

She'd forgotten about that. Oh no, this was going to go *terribly* .

Adora reached up and chewed a knuckle for a moment then closed her eyes and drew in a deep breath.

"I am a strong tree. I am an immovable boulder. I am a mighty horse."

"Horse, huh?"

Adora jolted, eyes widening in surprise. She stared at the pretty brunette - Catra? - who had her head poked into the curtained area. The woman was smirking. Adora huffed, “Ever heard of knocking?” she managed to get out.

The producer arched an eyebrow, “Well excuse me princess. Not exactly easy to knock on cloth, y’know?” she made a miming motion. Her expression softened, “You, y’know, all good?”

Adora had a retort, some platitude or confident words on the tip of her tongue. But she met that mixed-gaze, amber and blue eyes fixed on her own, and honesty poured out instead, “Terrified.”

Catra blinked, surprised, then chuckled, “Well, you’ll be ok. Casta’s great and, well, we ditched the other producer. She was *terrible* , always about the drama. So, it’s gonna be smooth sailing. Just go out there, ask the questions, make a joke, kiss the girl… done,” Catra looked away at that last comment and seemed to shrug. She seemed, in fact, to be having her own internal conversation, but turned back to Adora with a fixed smile, “So, uh, you all mic’d up?”

Adora nodded slowly, “I think the guy’s name was, um, Kyle?”

Catra blinked, then snorted loudly. Her hand came up to her mouth as she sputtered, before she calmed down, “Wh…no, I mean… *snrk* … your *microphone* .”

“Oh! Um. I knew that. Totally. Ha! Yes,” Adora winced, then sagged, “Wow, not had stage fright this bad since I had to do that whole thing at county.”

The brunette arched an eyebrow, “Thing?”

“Oh, um, yeah, did a horse dressage show,” Adora waved a hand absently, “Terrifying. Went well but, wow, Swifty and I we were just sweating buckets. I had to go do a whole circuit in the gym beforehand. You guys, uh, you don’t have any weights or, um, a heavy bag do you?”

Catra stared at her, then blinked, “I have… so many questions,” she murmured, then winced, before she cleared her throat, eyes flicking to Adora’s arms for a brief second, “Uh, so, um. Casta will be calling you out in a bit. We’re all set up. You got your questions?”

“Questions? Uh, yours? You said you had some?”

The brunette’s mouth twitched into another smirk, “No, I… ok *I* have questions but you. Your questions for the *contestants* .”

“OH! Them! Yes, uh…” Adora patted her dress, “No pockets, dammit, um… ah, here!” she plucked some cards from where she had them tucked in the dress. Catra looked away, flushed, but Adora didn’t notice, instead peering at the small cards, “Made them at home. In case I, uh… forgot.”

The brunette looked at Adora with the sort of expression one saves for a puppy that has just knocked over an ugly vase, "You… ok, we *have* your questions, but the show kinda… has its scripted one. Stops people getting, y'know… silly? Anyway, they're close-ish to yours. And on nice, sparkly cards. Clearly Kyle didn't give them to you," Catra tapped her headset and spoke softly into it. "Hey, Rogelio, first, slap Kyle round the head for me. Then bring me Adora's question cards. We're good to go in 2, ok, so step to it."

She smiled awkwardly at Adora, who looked sheepishly at her own, handmade effort. The blonde held them out and managed an embarrassed smile, "Um. I guess I… don't need these?"

Catra took them, then pocketed them with a chuckle, "Don't worry, Princess. You aren't the worst I've seen. One girl wanted to bring her pet robo-dog on set. *That* was a nightmare."

"OH! I remember that one. She went home with the goth guy, right?"

Catra chuckled, "Yeah. One of the show's *actual* success stories," she blanched, "Uh, not that, y'know… things don't work out. Just, it's, well, tricky?"

Adora nodded slowly, but before she could say anything a hand thrust a set of glittery cards, covered in stars, through the curtain. Catra rolled her eyes, took the cards from the hand, then passed them to Adora. The blonde smiled and managed a quiet, "Thanks."

For a moment, their fingers touched. Catra jerked her hand back and put her fingers to her headset, "Um, ok, so, yeah, uh… right, run through we're live in… um… when are… ok, yeah," she turned to go, paused and looked at Adora, "So, um. Like, good luck or whatever."

And with that, she was gone. Adora clutched the cards to her chest and let out a breath she hadn't even realised she was holding. She sat there, still, for a while, eyes staring blankly at the curtain, head a bit of a jumbled mess, until a voiceover from beyond the curtain dragged her back. She could just make out the tinny laughter of the audience and recognised the motherly, wry tones of the show's presenter, Casta. It sounded like she was going through the introductions of the suitors, but the sound didn't travel well, clearly being directed *forwards* . Plus she would bet the curtains were thick *and* the set was soundproofed. No way she could 'cheat'.

"Can you cheat on a dating show?" she pondered. "I mean, how would you? I suppose you could sample, but… oh I should've just tried that speed dating thingie…" she took another deep breath, "You *got* this Adora. You're going to stand tall, look Adam in the eye and tell him you DO have game."

She rolled her shoulders, then nodded to herself. A moment later, Kyle returned, looking sheepish, "Ok, we're on," he whispered, before leading her to the edge of the set. Adora could hear Casta's voice from the other side.

"So you've now met our three hopeful girls, it's time to see who they're hoping to go home with tonight. Or at least, get to first base! But our girl Adora doesn't play *that* sort of game, oh no! She's a fan of horsing about and loves her routine. Hailing from the county of Eternia, please welcome Adora Grey to *Mystacor Mix!"*

Adora swore she heard a loud yelp from somewhere on the set, but was too focused on her entrance and not toppling over on the, frankly, ridiculous heels. However, a youth of dressage competitions, horse riding and gymnasium attendance had given her a pretty good sense of balance and she managed to make it down the shallow steps from off stage and across the short expanse. Her nerves were ringing and she half turned to the audience with an only-faintly manic grin as she fired finger guns at them. The audience had been silent for a millisecond when she stepped out, but erupted into wolf whistles and applause as she strutted across the stage.

Casta seemed agog - the woman wore her trademark navy blue pant suit. She looked like a lecturer, but exuded a maternal authority. Or she normally did. Right now she looked stunned. Adora immediately felt a little self conscious - had her hair come loose? Had she smudged her makeup? Had the ink from the questions stained her dress, her chest, her…?

Her eyes flashed about and she caught a glimpse of brunette hair and a familiar face next to one of the cameras. Catra seemed to be staring as well, tablet held loosely in one hand.

If the *producer* (That's what Catra was, right? Adora felt she should have worked that out) was staring it must be bad? But

then Catra shook herself, grinned and gave Adora a double thumbs up.

The blonde managed to refocus on Casta, who had recovered and was now positively *beaming* , "ADORA! Welcome to the show," she announced as the applause died down.

"MARRY ME!" came a strangled male voice from the audience, mercifully in the dark thanks to the lighting.

Adora winced and immediately replied, before her brain could stop her, "Oh, honey, no…" in such a pitying voice it got a roar of cackled laughter from the audience, as well as some of the crew. Adora's smile was fixed and she turned to look at Casta. The presenter smirked and looked into the audience.

"I admore tenacity, ambition and determination. But, sir, I think you're not just barking up the wrong tree, I fear you're in entirely the wrong forest. Also, I believe every woman in the audience, admitted or not, would be shoving you out of the way, hmmm?"

Another laugh from the audience, mostly with nervous giggles amidst it. Adora frowned, but was pulled out of it as she watched Catra directing the cameras quietly. Casta led her to the lone stool and Adora hopped onto it easily, her gaze roaming the cameras and set as she tried to find something to focus on. She jolted as Casta spoke and Adora realised the woman was speaking to her.

"..three lovely ladies here this evening, all hoping for a shot. And of course, we have an all expenses paid spa trip and dinner date for you both to win! So, before we kick off, tell us a bit more about yourself Adora."

"Uhhhhhh," Adora smiled, a rather brittle expression, "I um…can bench press twice my own weight, I like horses and I can hold my breath for a minute and a half. Oh! And I can do this thing with my tongue…" Adora went a bit cross eyed but Casta managed to interrupt hurriedly.It was a little annoying - her party trick always got a good round of applause at parties, though she never understood why some of the girls looked a bit dazed afterwards. Or why some of her friends from the gym had asked her to " *teach me your ways!"* It was just a way to tie a lace in her mouth. Nothing special.

"Well! Quite the list of recommendations!" her grin was a little on the strained side, but the audience seemed to like it. Adora glanced at the cameras to see Catra leaning against one, with the black girl patting her on the back.

The show host managed to rally, "So, let's get right to it! Three questions, to identify whether your true love is here this evening! The power of divination! The magic of the mundane! Will sparks fly? Your first question, please, Adora…"

Adora nodded quickly, then shuffled the cards in her hand. She coughed into her fist and looked up, straight at the cameras, "So, um… number one. Uh… so…" she squinted at the card in front of her and sighed internally at the twee question. Her *original* questions had been a tad thematic, *maybe* . Maybe about gym

equipment and preferred horse hiking trails. But still! That was *her* .

But she had to make do with this, she supposed.

She cleared her throat and pressed on, her voice a little sing-song as she rattled off the questions. "Some people enjoy candle light and stars. Some are all about bungee jumping. How would you woo me?"

Who says WOO anymore?! Adora had to choke through that. She looked up at the cameras with a brittle smile. Catra was watching, a smirk on her face. For a moment, Adora wondered if she'd been set up, but the brunette gave a slight wince that looked more sympathetic than anything else.

Adora shuffled her cards and waited. Casta frowned as the silence stretched on and then leaned forwards a bit, "Contestant number one…?"

A squeak came from behind the screen, followed by a cough and the sound of a throat clearing. When the contestant spoke, their voice was weirdly deep. A woman trying to impersonate a man *badly* style of deep.

"Oh, um, well! Ha! So, totes romantic. Fer shuuuure, like, we'd take my, um, my uh *truck* . Yeah and, uh, go and um…" the voice coughed again.

“Are… are you ok?” Adora queried. Casta’s eyes rose and she placed a gentle hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“Probably just stage fright! It’s tricky, dear!”

The voice coughed again and this time spoke in a higher pitched voice. Adora’s eyebrows rose.

“I uh, I mean, well! Dancing. Yes! Dancing and, well, not just chillin’ in my apartment, reminiscing or…”

“GLIMMER?!”

Adora almost stood, but Casta’s grip tightened a little. The show host frowned at shot a confused look at the production staff. Catra had an eyebrow raised and was slowly turning to regard Kyle, who was flipping through what looked like a script.

Meanwhile, Adora was staring at the partition. There was a pause and a more normal very familiar voice came over it, “Oh, heh… Hey there Adora! So, um, I didn’t realise *you* were the, y’know… um… prize.. NO! Wait, not prize, um… contestant? So, uh… fancy seeing you here?”

“Glim! What… why are you here?”

“Well, y’know. It’s been… been ages since I dated and, well, I thought *why not* ?”

“Wait, did you and Bow break up?” Adora frowned, “We went out last week and you guys seemed fine!”

“Bow and… Adora we… we aren’t *dating* ! Bow doesn’t…” that drew a scandalised *gasp* from the audience.

“Are you sure? Because, well… he does all that opening doors thing, he takes your calls late at night,” Adora frowned and began absently listing reasons off her fingers, cards in her lap, “He picked us up that one time, late at night when you were really *really* si-”

“OK WE do NOT need to air that in PUBLIC!” came Glimmer’s high pitched voice, insistent and very much with a tone of *do not go there* . A ripple of laughter spread across the studio audience, who were lapping the whole thing up. “And… and that’s friend stuff. He’s *always* done that.”

Adora pressed on, slightly oblivious, “I mean, I guess. But then again he did turn down that one girl and those two guys who offered him their numbers. Remember? We went to the arcade, then that time at the movies, then when we were at that bar…”

“That… wait, what?”

“And of course he was talking about your *bestiversary…”*

“See!”

“Except he kinda looked a bit… manic when he said it. I mean, I’m a bit rusty at it but, thinking about it, I found it weird he’d refer to an anniversary like that. And he asked if I wouldn’t mind if it was just you two, and I said *of course! You and your girl need some special time!* And, y’know, I was jealous.Not because, y’know… I mean you’re hot Glim! And if you and Bow weren’t dating, maybe, I mean, but I know I’m not your type.”

Silence settled across the studio, with a few *awwws* from the audience. Catra had Kyle by the scruff of his collar, half lifted off the floor, but she was staring at the set instead. Casta’s jaw was slightly unhinged. From behind the barrier came a low whimper. Adora shrugged.

“”But, y’know, I wouldn’t get between friends like that. I did think it was weird when he laughed and said *my girl… right* . But I thought he was just… planning something?” Adora flexed her hands and sighed, “So, um… are you, um, answering th question?”

“We… he… oh god I need to get home! I need to call him! I told him about this and… oh stars he made this strangled yelp and…

oh he knew you were on! He must! Oh! Oh no!" There was a flash of purple sequins as Glimmer skittered around the partition on her flats. Her dress had a lot of flowy lavender lace as well and it billowed as she tottered towards Adora, before she flung herself at the blonde in a bear hug, "Thank you Adora, you are the *best* . And, um, for the record, if Bow and I… well, y'know you are *smoking* and I would be very very interested. But, y'know. Bow. Still besties?"

Adora grinned, "Besties. Now, go get your boy!"

Glimmer vanished off set, to cheers from the audience, pursued by a couple of gophers from the staff, yelling at her to *return the dress* ! Adora mused that that was very unlikely to happen - Glimmer tended to be a bit single minded when she was set on something. A tiny bulldozer.

"Well, um. That's a first," Casta managed to say. She shook her head and smiled at the cameras, "Can we, uh… fix that in post?"

Catra dropped Kyle and nodded slowly, "I… think we can work with that. Um.. Ok, so, uh… jeez thank the stars we aren't live. Could be good for ratings?"

Casta just shrugged, then fixed a more genuine grin on her face as she ad libbed, all smiles towards the audience, "Well that's one way to narrow down your choices! What an answer! So, the same question for our other two lovely ladies?"

Adora blinked, “Oh, well, sure?”

She had another *two* questions to get through. The second contestant spoke with a mellow tone that put Adora at ease immediately, “Well, for me, I think communing in a quiet place would be the most beneficial. To truly understand one another, to see our true selves, does not happen immediately. So, I’d like to take you down to explore my garden…” the mystery voice left the comment hanging and Adora quirked an eyebrow, unsure. It sounded a pretty tame date.

There were a few muffled chuckles and Casta laughed throatily, “Well now! Contestant two is promising an evening of horticultural excitement!”

Adora managed a nod and arched an eyebrow. She saw Catra staring at her again. The woman looked almost incredulous. The camerawoman, however, seemed focused on the other side of the partition. She looked to be a big lady, the camera dwarfed by her stature. For a moment, Adora felt a pang of jealousy - for her physique.of course. Catra appeared to be standing close to the woman too. Entirely separate things. Adora cleared her throat.

“And, um, for number three, the same?”

The next voice came out as bored drawl, “So, like, I love the sea, y’know? And it wouldn’t be, like, the sea that you be *swept away* by. An evening out with me and we’ll be making *waves* .”

Ah. Puns. That was it. Adora nodded slowly, understanding dawning. She saw Catra face-palm and couldn't help but smile. The brunette looked up and caught Adora grinning at her. She flushed and slapped the camerawoman on the arm, so it pivoted to the blonde. The big woman who, Adora noticed, had nearly white hair, seemed to shake herself out of a reverie and swiveled the camera.

Adora blinked and her smile became a little brittle but she shuffled her cards and cleared her throat, "So, um, second question to, uh…"

"We'll.. Fudge number one. Somehow," whispered Casta, smiling, "Just go ahead dear."

"Uh, so. I like to," she squinted, then looked up, "Wait, I don't do this? My worst habit isn't *leaving clothes out!* " Casta looked like a deer in headlights. Adora ploughed on, "No, I mean, I always put things away. Can't have dirty gym gear. Wearing that stuff is *ew* . No. I mean, I guess… maybe may eating? I mean I do just… chow down?" she frowned, eyes glazing over, "Adam says it's like watching a wolverine. Oh! Or maybe it's my sleep fighting? I do that a bit. Just in case, y'know! Be prepared!" She smiled, hopefully. The audience was in tears it seemed.

Catra had her fist shoved into her mouth and looked to be shaking again. The rest of the crew were studiously trying to maintain their composure. The camera-woman was nodding, as if in agreement.

Casta cleared her throat, "So, uh, *interesting!* We all have our quirks! So, dear, what's your question?"

"Oh!" Adora smiled brightly, "Sorry! Um, so, those are *my* bad habits, tell me YOURS!" she leaned into it, which got a laugh from around the studio. She beamed - she was getting *good* at this.

The second voice hummed, "I find balance is key, but it does mean I can sometimes be indecisive. I want to share my all, and changing is part of that, but also you need to sometimes *commit* to things. Which means I will spend hours and hours and *hours* on some things, because I just can't tear myself away. Focus can be good. Or it can be great."

"Doesn't sound like a flaw, " snorted Adora.

"Not if I'm doing things right," giggled the soothing voice. Adora blinked and made an *oooooh* expression. The audience laughed.

"And, um… the same for number three?"

"I guess she can focus on me if she wants," came the drawled voice. That got another chuckle from the audience and the crew, "But, uh, I guess… I suppose I get impatient. A bit. So, y'know, like, time's-a-wasting, I won't be wasting *your* time, and you'll not be sleep fighting me. Cos, like, you'll be y'know… all washed up. I'm a bit of a messy eater too."

“Well, good to know you’re like me when it comes to keeping things, um, tidy and getting laundry done.” Adora nodded confidently, then frowned, “I… think?”

The audience made *awww* noises at that. Adora chanced a glance at the crew and saw that Catra was looking at her with a smile, an almost disbelieving expression on her face.

Casta spoke up, “Well now. It’s final question time! And…”

“MERMISTA!” The shout came from the audience. The audience and Crew turned as one and a loud *UGH* came from behind the partition. A man stood at the back of the studio, dressed up in some sort of attempt at ren faire re-enactment, or so it seemed. His blue shirt was unbuttoned down to his abs, whilst his black trousers clung to him like a second skin. Adora arched an eyebrow - she respected the man’s fashion choices. Bold.

Catra turned and gawked, “You… please sir, settle down or we’ll have to get security…”

“Never! None shall stand betwixt me and my truest love! Mermista! I have come to profess my ardent and true devotio-”

“There’s a *restraining order* Hawk!” came that drawling voice, except now it sounded exasperated, “You are doing the *worst* … I am *trying* to move. On. But noooo, you just have to…”

“This torch represents my burning desire for your forgiveness. And, um,” the man flourished an *actual torch* , swathed in cloth, which he lifted into the air, “And, well… I just wanted to say… I am so sorry, Mermista. I let you down. I shouldn’t have tried that stunt with your father’s car. I was just… trying to show you how… well, I just…”

The man sagged, then rallied, and lit the torch. Catra yelped out a warning, “No! No naked flames in here!”

“Nakedness is my intention, but only with my sea-star’s true consent, blessing and forgiveness! I would traverse Hell! I would wrestle all manner of low-rent security! I would cross oceans for you, my love…” the man skipped through the audience and plucked a small box from his back pockets as he approached. Kyle tried to intercept him, but the man actually *danced* around him and Kyle ran into the audience instead, leading to several confused yelps.

The voice - Mermista? - sighed, “You just don’t give up. How many times do I have to tell you…?”

“This one last time. I promise. I… this is all or nothing, my love. Cast me aside and I will be gone. But let me say this one last thing.” Adora noticed a pair of large men had lumbered onto the set, wearing the tight black-shirts of studio security. They were all muscle and zero neck. The pair spotted Hawk and began to move towards him. The man noticed them too and spoke faster, “So, it is with this last ditch hope that I can redeem myself, follow through and be the man you need me to be. I have sold my boat. I have paid my debts. I have gotten a job. And… this is what I wanted to ask you, Mermista…”

With the torch held along, he managed to flick open the small box with one hand. Adora could only see him, not the woman hidden behind the screen. But her sudden sniffle was loud enough to carry across the room, "Ugh you… dumb. Stupid… ugh!" A vision in a blue and teal jumpsuit came into view and practically glomphed the man, just as the security reached him. A rather complicated spectacle ensued and suddenly the woman was lunging for one of the men, yelling "Hands off! He's mine!" Hawk himself was actually trying to extricate himself, but unsuccessfully.

This resulted in the torch suddenly pitching up and over the set where it rolled to a stop at the rear. There was a muffled *whoomph* and the cheap paint-and-plywood backdrop went up like a kerosene soaked candle.

"Everyone out!" yelled Catra, "Fire esca-" but her yells were drowned out by the audience shrieks as they all began to scramble away. Adora watched, bemused, as the muscular camera-woman lurched across the set, then vanished behind the partition. She returned a second later, a blond woman with tanned skin, freckles, and a billowy green dress draped over her shoulders in a fireman-carry. The blonde shot Adora a smile and waved, then shrugged. Adora gave her a dazed thumbs up.

Casta was yelling, trying to rally the set when there was a sudden *click* and the sprinklers activated. With a *whoosh* , everyone was drenched, which caused more shrieks and yells. With a fizz and a pop, the set lights failed. Adora sighed and looked down at her cards, then reached up to wipe away the now-running make up from her face. She stood and walked towards the exits, as others scrambled to leave. Behind her the set crunched and crashed as

the props burned, the flames putting up a valiant fight against the water.

There was a crunch as one of the light-riggings collapsed, crushing more of the set and scattering sparks.

Adora shook her head and sighed, "Well… fu-"

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Thirty minutes later she was sat outside on the street, along with most of the crew and the audience. The fire department had the blaze under control and most of the paramedics were just treating people for mild shock or over-excitement. Across the way, Hawk and Mermista were being loaded into police cars, shouting out their declarations of mutual love to one another, along with Mermista's promise to get her dad to bail them *both* out.

The second contestant and the camera-woman were sat by one of the ambulances, the muscular crew-woman fussing over the blonde. Adora smiled at that.

A bag landed in front of her and she looked up into a set of amber and blue eyes. Catra grinned, "DT saved your clothes. And your wallet and, y'know, other stuff?" the producer scratched at her neck, "You, uh… you ok?"

Adora smiled, “Thanks. And I’m fine,” she shrugged and bit her lip, “I mean, of all the ways to crash and burn… actually crashing and burning *wasn’t* on my expected plans for the evening.”

Catra cackled at that, then moved to sit next to her, “Yeah, I mean… first time for me too!”

“Will… will you guys be ok? I mean, you lost the set.”

Catra just waved a hand, “That set cost two hundred bucks at *most* . And it was built ten years ago. Studio insurance will cover it. Plus, this show? Hearing Casta, this is going to be a *killer* ratings wise,” she shrugged, “Life gives you lemons, I suppose. Never used to think that, but Casta… she has a way of turning things around. Of course… she’ll need your OK for the permissions and stuff. And way I hear it, seeing as you didn’t actually get a date…” the brunette shrugged and looked away “Maybe you could come back, do a re-run?”

Adora sighed, “I think… I think that’d be a bad idea,” she sagged and shook her head, “Think I’m just gonna accept that… this is it. I’m done. This was pretty clearly a sign from the gods.”

Catra looked at her and arched an eyebrow, “Oh?”

“Yep. Perpetual singledom calls to me. I need to just accept it. Devote myself to being a gym beast, maybe get into personal training. Invent new protein shakes. Adopt, like, ten golden

retrievers and five cats. Move to a cottage and, I dunno, take up sword collecting or something. That's what lesbian spinsters do, right?" she shook her head.

Catra frowned, "Seriously? I mean… I mean *look* at you. How are you *not* beating women off with a stick?"

"I am RUBBISH at it. Dating. Or… or spotting if someone likes me. Like, big ol' blind spot, right here!" Adora exclaimed.She flung her hands up, then gestured at her drenched dress and lank hair, "And I am… look at me! I look like I just got dunked."

"Still beautiful," murmured Catra, before she jolted and glanced away. She coughed and then licked her lips. For a moment, the brunette stared off into the middle distance. She took a deep breath, "So, uh… hiking. To tall places. For views."

Adora blinked, confused, then looked at Catra, "What?"

"My perfect date. Used to hate exercise, but, well, getting up high. Hiking or, like, finding a building that has good views. Love it. Gives life new perspective. And, uh…my temper. I'm jealous. Got a therapist though. Serious abandonment issues, BUT I'm working on it. Got a cat, helps too. That's uh… that's my worst quality."

The crowd began to thin as the responders let people go. Adora just stared at Catra, confused, "Oh…kay?"

“And uh… I prefer, like, brunch. Y’know, waffles, but you can have a milkshake too? Cheating, I know.”

That made Adora cock her head and her eyes narrowed, “That… that was my third question…”

“Yeah, breakfast or dinner. So, y’know, those are my answers,” The brunette hugged her knees to her chest and she offered a small shrug.

“Why?” Adora blinked. Catra looked confused and Adora reached out and gripped the other woman’s forearm, “Like I said. Big. Old. Blind spot.”

Catra’s gaze met hers, “Do you think you would, y’know… consider a date?”

“Which one?” Adora responded automatically. She bit her lip and exhaled, “Sorry.. Um. To be clear. Are you, uh…Catra… asking me out on a *date* ? Or do you want to know about a *specific* date?”

The brunette’s expression shifted from nervy to smirk in a moment, “Such an idiot,” she murmured. But it was layered with softness and an almost familiar fondness. The woman inhaled slowly, “A bit of column a, a bit of column b? Kinda, I want to know about a specific date… to take you on a date?”

“Now? Now is good,” Adora blurted, “But, uh… I… oh gosh too soon, I mean we just met and…” she froze as Catra reached forward and gently grasped her chin. The brunette leaned forwards until their foreheads met.

“Coffee?”

“Coffee… would be great,” Adora breathed.

Catra beamed, a look of sudden relief on her face. “Hoo boy. That was… scary.”

“Tsch! No. You are *gorgeous* . No way you struggle.”

Catra cocked her head, “Gorgeous huh?”

Adora met her gaze, “Yes. Utterly gorgeous.”

The brunette flushed and looked away, then stood abruptly. Adora blinked, unsure, but relaxed as Catra turned and offered Adora her hand. She smiled down at the blonde softly, “You comin’, Princess?”

End Notes

Hey all! Just a tiny one shot (18 pages!) to help break me outta my writing funk. Thank you all for your patience and I hope you enjoyed this little bite of madness.

As ever, comments are always appreciated!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!